



GETTY IMAGES

ZHANG YINING

China has produced several outstanding table tennis players who have dazzled with a superior craft that other nations have been unable to match. One such player was Zhang Yining, the two-time Olympic champion who held the No. 1 ranking for over six years between 2003 and 2009, with a break of only two months in between in 2008. Born in Beijing in 1981, Zhang came through the well-established Chinese system, making her debut with the national team at the 1999 World Championships and ending with silver. She was to again lose in the Worlds final two years later but was rarely defeated after that. Zhang ended her career with four Olympic and

10 World Championships gold medals, besides four World Cup wins. Like other formidable Chinese players, Zhang displayed the same ruthlessness both on the table and away. Her proficient skills and speed were a sight to behold as she mercilessly downed her opponents, delivering topspin forehands with consistency.

But what earned this player with the shakehand grip the moniker "Yellow Beast" was how she waylaid her rivals with her backhand. She could lay down a blizzard on the other end of the table, providing opponents with little chance to retrieve or forcing them to commit unforced errors.